

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

28 October 2014

To an individual Bahá'í

1 Dear Bahá'í Friend,

2 The Universal House of Justice has received your email letter of 17 September 2014 in which you and your husband, ..., seek guidance regarding the disposition of embryos and has asked that we reply as follows.

3 The Bahá'í view of matters pertaining to infertility is balanced. While it appreciates the value of medical techniques that enable previously childless couples to enjoy the blessings of a family, the teachings define such limits as are necessary to preserve the dignity of the individual and the sanctity of marriage.

4 The House of Justice does not wish to legislate at this time on the disposition of any embryos following the in vitro fertilization process. Hence, for the time being, it is left to the Bahá'í couple to decide what to do with the unused embryos.

5 In your letter you mention the possibility of donating the embryos to another couple seeking fertility treatment. Statements made by the beloved Guardian establish the principle that, for Bahá'ís, the process of reproduction pertains to a husband and wife. Furthermore, the option you have suggested, which involves the adoption by one couple of an embryo derived from the sperm and ovum of another couple and implanted in the womb of the adoptive mother, is very closely related to the concept of surrogacy and raises additional complex issues. As you know, the House of Justice has determined that the spiritual and social implications involved in surrogacy are too far-reaching for such procedures to be permissible for Bahá'ís. In light of this, the option of your donating the remaining embryos to another couple would not be acceptable.

6 As you consider this matter, you may find it helpful to take into account that while the Bahá'í Writings affirm that the human soul comes into being at the time of conception, they do not clearly define the exact biological moment and nature of the event described as "conception", and this may, indeed, be a question that is insoluble by human thought or investigation since it relates to mysteries of the spiritual world and the nature of the soul itself.

7 Be assured of the supplications of the House of Justice in the Holy Shrines that you may be guided and assisted by the Blessed Beauty.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]